the trusts are estimated to have made donations worth over $102.4 billion (Rs 8.6 lakh crore) to philanthropic causes till 2021, as per the 2021 EdelGive Hurun Philanthropists of the Century report. In FY23, which are the latest figures available, Tata Trusts disbursed Rs 456.4 crore for various causes.

But what gives Tata Trusts its major clout is the sweeping powers it has over Tata Sons, being its largest shareholder. All major decisions of the group companies, including raising capital, buyback options or any change in articles of association (AoA), have to be discussed with the trustees. It also decides on the dividends it has to gain from group companies, which are diverted to various philanthropic activities. In FY24, Tata Trusts reportedly received its highest ever dividend of Rs 933.4 crore from Tata Sons, more than double the Rs 466.7 crore it received the previous fiscal. As per their 2023 annual report, the trusts distributed 48.5 per cent of their funds to healthcare, 16.9 per cent for rural upliftment, 16.5 per cent for education and 10.4 per cent to institutions and the remaining for water, urban poverty alleviation and energy.

Under Ratan Tata, say insiders, operations of Tata Trusts became "professionalised". To begin with, the trusts moved out of Bombay House, the headquarters of the Tata Group. Now, they have a new premise at the World Trade Centre in Cuffe Parade. Then, a number of senior executives were appointed to handle various functions—finance, digital, human resources, partnerships and resource mobilisation among them—much like a company. Insiders say that the structure has been laid so well that Noel, who already has his hands full running other corporate affairs, will not find it difficult to fit into the groove.

Worthy Successor

"Both Noel and Ratan Tata have shared the same vision and the same wavelength," says Ranina, who expects activities at Tata Trusts to gather momentum under its new chairman, since his predecessor had not been in good health and could not involve himself much with the trusts' activities in recent years. "Noel is much younger, and will be able to play a much more active role," he adds.

WHAT NOEL TATA WILL OVERSEE

Tata Trusts comprises two major trusts named after the sons of Jamsetji Tata and each housing several others engaged in philanthropic activities

SIR RATAN TATA TRUST

Established in 1919

- **BAI HIRABAI J.N. TATA NAVSARI CHARITABLE INSTITUTION** Established in Dec. 1923, has had the same trustees as Sir Ratan Tata Trust, which has played a pioneering role in redefining charity
- **NAVAJBAI RATAN TATA TRUST** Founded in memory of Sir Ratan Tata's wife Navajbai in 1974, works with Sir Ratan Tata Trust to bestow grants
- **SARVAJANIK SEVA TRUST** Registered in 1975, provides grants to individuals for medical treatment besides scholarships to deserving students to pursue higher studies in India
- **TATA EDUCATION AND DEVELOPMENT TRUST** Set up in 2008, its activities are multifaceted in nature, primarily focusing on social welfare and national development

SIR DORABJI TATA TRUST

Established in 1932

- **THE JN ENDOWMENT FOR THE HIGHER EDUCATION OF INDIANS** Has been helping Indian students since 1892 with loan scholarships for higher studies
- **LADY TATA MEMORIAL TRUST** Also established in 1932, it funds individual scientific research into diseases of the blood and individual/institutional research into other diseases in India
- **LADY MEHERBAI D TATA EDUCATION TRUST** Founded in 1932, it gives scholarships to women graduates for pursuing higher studies abroad
- **JRD TATA TRUST** Founded in 1944, offers institutional grants with focus on developmental issues. Also gives scholarships to study in India
- **JAMSETJI TATA TRUST** Founded in 1974, offers institutional grants centred on overall developmental issues, and has the same programme mandate as the parent trust
- **TATA EDUCATION TRUST, TATA SOCIAL WELFARE TRUST AND RD TATA TRUST** Created in 1990, their primary focus is institutional grants
- **JRD AND THELMA J TATA TRUST** Established in 1991 by JRD Tata, aims at promoting the welfare, education, health, rehabilitation and upliftment of women in India



CHANGE OF GUARD
A file photo of Noel Tata with Ratan Tata